

Ehrlichiosis — What you need to know

A tick-borne infection that responds well to early treatment

Ehrlichiosis is a bacterial infection spread by ticks. In Arizona, dogs are the most common reservoir, and the brown dog tick is the main vector. Like Rocky Mountain Spotted Fever, ehrlichiosis can become serious if not treated quickly, and treatment is started based on symptoms even before lab confirmation.

Symptoms

- Fever and chills
- Severe headache
- Muscle aches
- Nausea or vomiting
- Tiredness
- Sometimes a rash (less common than in RMSF)

What you should do

1. Take **doxycycline** as prescribed for 7 to 14 days, even if you feel better quickly.
2. Tell anyone in your household who develops fever in the next 14 days that they were exposed and need to see a doctor.
3. Treat all dogs in the household for ticks with a vet-recommended preventive.
4. Inspect your home and yard for ticks. Brown dog ticks live in cracks, dog houses, and bedding.

If your dog was diagnosed first

Ehrlichiosis is not contagious between people or directly between pets and people, but everyone in the household is exposed to the same ticks. If your dog was diagnosed with ehrlichiosis, watch yourself and other family members for symptoms for the next 14 days, treat all pets with tick preventive, and clean tick habitat from the home and yard.

Recovery

With early treatment, most people recover fully within 1 to 2 weeks. Severe disease is uncommon when treatment starts within the first 5 days of symptoms.

Call your doctor if you have:

- Fever after a tick bite or after a household pet is diagnosed with a tick-borne disease
- Severe headache or stiff neck
- Inability to keep medications down due to vomiting

More information

- Arizona Department of Health Services: 602-364-4562
- CDC Ehrlichiosis page: cdc.gov/ehrlichiosis

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